The Right to Emotional Access in Digital Systems

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A White Paper by the Neural Commons Collective

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Notes: A list of key terms is included in the appendix.

Introduction

As digital systems become central to how people access services, participate in culture, and engage with institutions, an expanded definition of access is required which extends further than mere functionality. This paper explores why users of digital systems and spaces should have the means to navigate systems emotionally, cognitively, and safely.

This goal can be achieved by introducing emotional access as an essential aspect of digital inclusion. Building upon current accessibility and digital inclusion frameworks (such as the EU Accessibility Act, Web Content Accessibility Guidelines, and the United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities), prioritising emotional access in digital environments adds a new dimension to conversations around equity, trust, and inclusion that serve to benefit underserved users.

Patterns from user feedback, accessibility research, and inclusive design consistently point to a gap between how digital systems function and how they feel. Across sectors, platforms are often experienced as emotionally disconnected - rushed, impersonal, or mismatched to diverse cognitive styles. Even with strong examples of good practice, emotional dissonance in UX can quietly erode engagement, trust, and the overall effectiveness of online services.

Executive Summary

This paper presents a core proposition:

Emotionally safe and cognitively supported digital systems go beyond the legal compliance of inclusion to facilitate improved user experience.

While digital rights frameworks often focus on transparency, privacy, and utility, they usually overlook the most immediate layer of interaction: how a system feels to use. The right to not be overwhelmed, to feel welcomed and understood, and to engage through tone, rhythm, and resonance must be considered as vital parts of digital equity.

This white paper outlines why emotional access matters, who it affects, and how digital systems can be reimagined to support cognitive and emotional diversity. Access needs to be more than transactional, and human-centred systems need to move beyond functionality to foster emotional trust (systems that do not tax, shame, ignore or exhaust), attunement, and presence.

1 System Design and Access

The Problem

Data shows us that people all over the world are using digital services for a wider variety of activities and needs. Digital access is no longer a luxury, but rather a

necessity if people want to access essential services such as education, health, and finance.

Many people are excluded from digital environments not because they can't interact with the system functionally, but because the experience is emotionally misaligned. Research in philosophy and cognitive science has shown how digital systems offer powerful forms of "affective scaffolding" that structure our motivations, feelings, appetites and moods, sometimes in negative ways. Interfaces are often considered too fast, formal, or overwhelming and many are designed with assumptions about linear thinking, certainty, and cognitive ease. These assumptions are centred on the misconception that we all have the same kind of mind, and thus approach digital context from an identical platform. The science of inner experience shows that this is not the case.

Modern design choices such as pacing, tone, layout, and interaction patterns, not only compromise usability, but are complicit in the structural exclusion of users who process information differently.

In a focus group compromising of 45 neurodivergent and neurotypical participants, who were invited to share experiences of digital platforms, they described emotional disconnection in subtle but consistent ways. We identified three main themes in the collected responses: the importance of considerate interaction and pacing, building trust, and centring inclusive design in digital systems. For instance:

Interaction and Pacing

Participants discussed how digital systems should feel active and responsive, but also emphasised that they should not be manipulated to stay on the platform. Participants appreciated "spaces that encourage me to take a break and pace myself". Individualisation was discussed heavily, and the feeling of being rushed and jumping through narrow hoops was "stressful" and "frustrating". Ultimately, participants wanted to explore how notifications could be used "to support people rather than being manipulative", and that the never-ending stream of notifications "feels like someone tapping my shoulder every 3 seconds". Having direct access to support staff over automated support was also a common request. Moreover, in discussions of accessibility, there was an important distinction outlined: "accessibility isn't just about "can you use it?" It's about "can you use it without hurting yourself?" and this was linked directly to system features, such as acknowledging "that my brain doesn't run on "default settings." I need clarity over cleverness, options over assumptions, and control over chaos". Finally, notions of successful or helpful systems were identified as making space for "genuine empathy in copywriting - not just "We care" but "Here's how we'll help."

Digital Trust

Trusting digital systems was also a key concern, especially during discussions of emotional access "I don't want to have to engage with an emotional response in a

digital space if I do not want to". Participants noted that they needed the ability to be anonymous, and this was linked to safety various times: "a sense of belonging requires sense of trust… which requires a sense of safety... which hinges on feeling like it's a space with respect, openness, non-defensiveness, curiosity, flexibility, honesty, clarity". Community was also discussed hand in hand with perceptive of a trustworthy system. Transparency about other actors or members of a system was also discussed: "I feel I belong when I can see who else is in that space and who has access to it." Generally, participants were weary of bad actors and prioritised "digital spaces that are not trying to exploit me, or use dark patterns to force my behaviour". It was also apparent to clarify emotion-led design with surveillance or exploitative monitoring "I do not want a system to monitor my mental state. It seems incredibly invasive and dangerous"

Design

Participants were clear that "neurodivergent and disabled users are often expected to adapt to systems, rather than systems adapting to them" and linked this to probing questions such as "whose discomfort have we normalised and whose comfort have we deprioritised in digital design?". Successful systems were noted to be ones that "reflects my reality, not an idealised user" and spaces that "proudly state it is designed by a neurodiverse team". Following this, including neurodivergent people at all stages of the design process who highlighted as an effective way of ensuring systems are inclusive and accessible.

Many modern digital systems are designed not just to guide users, but to keep them. Habit-forming interfaces, infinite scroll, and persuasive UX techniques are common practice – often rewarding repetition over reflection. While such patterns may support engagement metrics, they can compromise emotional autonomy and wellbeing, an impact increasingly noted in younger age groups as negatively affecting their digital experiences.

Moreover, engaging with digital systems is no longer optional in most contexts. Digital systems impact upon everyone; creating emotionally safe experiences should therefore be a right, not an optional or superficial feature.

Emotional Access offers a counterpoint: an approach that prioritises presence, attunement, and emotional safety over retention or compulsion. Consequently, as engaging in these digital systems is no longer optional, these platforms must go beyond our current definitions of user-friendly and accessible.

Typical design frameworks still treat mood as a visual choice and tone as a secondary concern. The result is a landscape of platforms that might be technically accessible but are emotionally exclusionary.

What Is Emotional Access?

Emotional access means being able to engage with a system in a way that feels emotionally safe, cognitively manageable, and aligned with the user's way of making sense of the world.

Emotional access provides comprehension through tone and rhythm, not just language and clarity.

To enable emotional access is to ensure that users can:
• Be met where they are, not where the system assumes they are
• Navigate at a pace that supports trust and comprehension
• Recognise themselves in the emotional tone and interaction logic
• Engage through sensory, symbolic, or affective pathways (potential to embrace on-linear design)

In observed feedback, users describe platforms that give them "space to breathe" as more usable, even when they contain the same information. The difference isn't the content itself. It's how the system feels that makes up "the essential building blocks of experience" (Swink, 2008).

Emotional access is therefore not an optional enhancement, but a critical component of inclusion. This is mirrored by the sentiment that this is an emerging feature of UX design: "the defining characteristic for an app won't be its functionality; it will be how it makes users feel" (Andrew Hogan, *Figma Head of Insights,* 2025).

Moving Beyond Preference

Digital platforms are increasingly responsible for delivering public goods – from benefits and housing to healthcare, education, and cultural participation. In these contexts, emotional access becomes a necessary part of functional access.

A system might technically function, but if users disengage, access has not been achieved.

Positioning emotional access as a right means:

• Designers need to take responsibility for emotional tone, not just structural logic
• Public services have to account for cognitive difference and emotional states, not just readability scores
• Digital regulation should address affective risk and emotional exclusion
• Institutions must recognise emotional design as part of digital equity

When people disengage, not out of confusion but because the system feels emotionally unwelcoming, exclusion has already happened. Rights frameworks exist to prevent that kind of quiet departure.

Who This Affects

Emotional access may affect a wide range of users, including:

• Neurodivergent people who process through rhythm, metaphor, or nonverbal logic

• Multilingual speakers who connect first through tone and structure, not content
• People in distress or cognitive overload, for whom the emotional pacing of a system matters more than clarity
• Sensory-first individuals who are sensitive to tone, pressure, and interaction style
• Users impacted by age who relate to systems through exploration and mood
• Anyone who has ever felt a system wasn't built for someone like them

Users describe their experience in emotional terms – phrases such as "I didn't feel welcome," "It was too much," "I couldn't stay with it" are ultimately describing an access barrier.

These emotional responses point to something deeper than interface friction, they show the cost of being in systems not built for your emotional tempo. As constant engagement becomes the norm – especially for younger users – rest, silence, and non-verbal communication aren't just design options. They're survival needs, offering new mechanisms of access centred through rest, perceptual pacing, and interaction styles that do not depend on speed or speech.

2 Emotional Access Through Rest and Non-Verbal Design

The Limits of Engagement-Centric UX

Young users, especially those in Gen Z and Gen Alpha, now move through digital spaces shaped by emotional saturation, crisis fatigue, and relentless algorithmic acceleration. A 2022 Pew Research study found that nearly half of U.S. teens describe themselves as "online almost constantly," up from just 24 percent in 2014. In the UK, NHS Digital reports that the share of children aged 7–16 with probable mental health conditions rose from 12 percent in 2017 to 18 percent in 2022.

Recent data from the British Standards Institution (BSI) adds a staggering new dimension: 47 percent of young Britons (aged 16–21) would prefer to grow up without the internet, and 68 percent say online life leaves them feeling worse about themselves. These numbers reinforce the impression that digital saturation is not just a trend, but a societal turning point demanding design rethink.

These figures reflect more than screen use; they indicate a psychological toll tied to persistent engagement. Platforms optimised for likes, speed, and virality may be alienating users whose emotional bandwidth and linguistic fluency are limited. The challenge is no longer just reach; it is resonance without exhaustion, accessibility without overwhelm.

These aren't just statistics about screen time, they're indicators of a deeper burden: the psychological toll of persistent, unrelenting engagement.

For decades, media platforms, public and commercial alike, have optimized for attention capture, speed, and click-through. But that playbook is starting to fray. The very users these systems are designed to serve, especially those with limited attention, emotional capacity, or linguistic ease, are increasingly fatigued. Reaching

young audiences is no longer the sole challenge. Reaching them without overwhelming them may be the real test.

Designing for Rest, Rhythm, and Regulation

Rather than pushing users to stay, scroll, and respond, we might ask, what if digital systems let them slow down?

This section proposes a pivot, from momentum to rhythm. That is, building interfaces that align with users' emotional and cognitive pace, not race ahead of it.

There's precedent in unexpected places:
• ASMR communities and ambient computing tools
• Breath-guided meditation apps and prayer interfaces
• Slow-TV formats and intentionally minimalist UIs

What binds these examples is not entertainment value, but co-regulation - the idea that design can stabilize rather than stimulate.

Within this framework, emotional access might look like:
• Perceptual pacing, chunking content into manageable pieces, embedding natural pause points, or inviting users to check back when ready
• Rest-positive UX, features that suggest breaks or decelerate information delivery when cognitive overload is likely
• Modal empathy, user-defined modes, fast or slow, skimmable or immersive, visual or textual, allowing control over input style and tempo

For neurodivergent users, including those with ADHD, autistic spectrum conditions, or sensory processing sensitivity, these aren't luxuries. They are what make the system usable at all. According to Microsoft's Inclusive Design Toolkit (2021) and the ADHD Foundation (2023), low-stimulation modes and rhythm-aware design directly improve comprehension, trust, and retention.

Beyond Language: Designing for the Unspoken

Most digital platforms still rely heavily on linguistic input. Search bars, comment threads, chatbot prompts, and feedback forms all assume fluent, fast, and verbal engagement. But that assumption excludes a quiet majority.

People who are non-speaking, multilingual, neurodivergent, or navigating trauma often communicate through very different modalities. You'll find expression in:
• Emoji strings and GIF sequences
• Visual moodboards or stylized collages
• Gesture-based apps or voice notes with long silences
• Delayed responses, or no response at all, as meaningful acts

These are not signs of disengagement. They are forms of post-verbal literacy, and often, they're more emotionally honest than typed responses.

Designing for the unspoken means decentring language as the sole mode of input. It invites new interaction grammars, ones based on rhythm, pattern, feeling, and pause.

Platform Implications: Designing for the Quiet Majority

This shift isn't about adding one more feature. It's about questioning the assumptions baked into how platforms define communication and participation.

If emotional access is the goal, then platforms across news, learning, entertainment, or messaging might consider:
• Slow-viewing options for crisis-heavy or emotionally charged topics
• Non-verbal feedback loops, like emoji-only responses, mood dials, or tap-to-reflect gestures
• Rest-first formats, such as low-stimulus audio playlists or scrollable digests designed for reflection
• Tempo-responsive interfaces that sense and adapt to user hesitation or lingering
• Inclusive co-design labs with users who don't default to language, such as non-speaking autistic teens, English as a Second Language (ESL) learners, visual communicators, and trauma survivors

If platforms begin treating silence, nonlinearity, and sensory refusal as valid signals, then we shift from a paradigm of extraction to one of care.

From Feature to Ethic: Making Emotional Access the Norm

It's not enough to add emotional access. The future lies in systems where care is built in, not bolted on.

That means:
• Developing Rest UX standards to assess perceptual and cognitive load
• Building post-verbal interaction libraries for designers, including icons, gestures, ambient cues, and rhythm-based triggers
• Establishing ethical nudging policies to govern push frequency, tone, and urgency thresholds
• Running cross-disciplinary design sprints that bring together neurodivergent youth, trauma-informed educators, speech therapists, and calm-tech developers

These aren't just ethical gestures. They are operational necessities. In a world where users increasingly drop out not from boredom but from burnout, rest becomes the only viable long game. And emotional access becomes a matter of system survival.

Emotional UX Is Becoming Infrastructure

What once seemed speculative is already in motion.

Mental Health and Emotional Design Are Entering the Mainstream
• Platforms like Apple's iOS now include built-in mood tracking and mindfulness tools, signalling growing integration of emotional well-being into core operating systems.

• YouTube and other digital platforms have introduced features like “take a break” reminders and curated mental health content, reflecting rising awareness of user mental states.
• Social platforms such as TikTok and Instagram are under increasing public and regulatory scrutiny around their impact on mental health, particularly in relation to attention fatigue and creator burnout.
• The growth of apps like Calm and Headspace underscores a clear demand for cognitive restoration over constant stimulation, with millions of users turning to these tools for digital downtime.

Post-Verbal and Neurodivergent UX Principles Are Gaining Traction
• While not yet standardised, past W3C efforts like EmotionML highlight early interest in multimodal interaction including emotional cues like voice tone and non-verbal input.
• Tools such as Notion’s Mood Tracker and emerging emotion-aware interfaces offer a glimpse into feeling-first design, prioritising how users feel over how they perform.
• These trends support a broader shift toward inclusive UX design - one that values silence, latency, and gesture as meaningful forms of interaction, particularly for neurodivergent users.

Digital Care Is Becoming a Strategic Design Focus
• Organisations such as Mozilla and research institutions like MIT are actively investing in trustworthy AI, ethical design, and emotionally-aware technologies, touching adjacent themes like calm tech and digital consent.
• These efforts point to a future where digital products don’t just work, they care: prioritising psychological well-being, user autonomy, and emotional literacy in everyday interactions.

3 Recommendations and Call to Action

Why This Matters Now

Across industries, we are beginning to witness a redefinition of what it means to access a system. It is no longer about technical entry or linguistic fluency. It is about emotional readiness.

This points to a series of near-future shifts:
• From Engagement to Regulation, measuring not time-on-platform, but how users feel when they leave
• From Input to Ambience, designing for rhythm, hesitation, and indirectness
• From Personalisation to Empathic Infrastructure, building systems that adapt to user emotional states, not just preferences
• From Feedback to Co-Creation, centring design around those whose voices are less often heard or felt

These are not minor UX tweaks. They are strategic, cultural, and ethical shifts toward platforms that not only inform or entertain, but offer space, pause, and emotional refuge.

Not all users speak in words. Not all drop-offs are disengagement. To build emotional access is to build systems that rest before they respond.

With rest, rhythm, and emotional safety in mind, we can now turn to the practical question: how do we actually design for emotional access?

Designing for Emotional Access

Designing for emotional access might include:
• Letting users select tone, pacing, or energy modes before entering a process
• Offering rhythm-based or sensory navigation options in place of step-by-step forms
• Using colour, sound, and layout to guide trust and comfort, not just direction
• Writing interface copy that anticipates emotional states, not just actions
• Designing nonlinear paths for those who don't arrive with a clear question
• Resisting urgency

Some of these approaches are beginning to surface in cultural and therapeutic design contexts. Others are still emerging, but they're grounded in strong signals of need. Across feedback, users respond positively to systems that "feel calm," "don't expect me to be perfect," or "make room for how I think."

These approaches point toward a deeper shift. They move us from efficiency alone toward systems that listen and respond with users' needs.

Design Commitments for Emotional Access

To create systems that support emotional access, we propose six core design commitments:

1. Emotional Legibility
Make tone, pace, and mood visible and adaptable.

2. Cognitive Respect
Embrace the diversity of inner experience, including symbolic, intuitive, and nonlinear cognition, without treating them as exceptions.

3. Trustworthy Atmosphere
Ensure the emotional tone feels human, accessible, and stable, even when content is complex.

4. Rhythmic Flexibility
Allow users to slow down, pause, or drift.

5. Nonlinear Entry
Support wandering, curiosity, and incomplete questions. Move away from assumptions of goal-based behaviour.

6. Affect Awareness
Assess emotional impact, not just usability, during testing and iteration.

This includes developing attunement metrics - ways to evaluate how a system's tone, rhythm, or atmosphere align with the emotional needs of users. These could involve reflection prompts, user-defined pacing, or experiential feedback focused on trust and cognitive ease.

Policy Recommendations

To embed emotional access into digital rights frameworks and public-facing systems, we recommend:
1. Formal recognition of emotional access within EU, UK, and international digital inclusion standards
2. Emotional tone and pacing evaluations as part of service design audits
3. Targeted funding for mood-led design research led by neurodivergent, trauma-informed, and multilingual communities
4. Expansion of accessibility law to include interpretive and emotional interaction modes
5. Development of best-practice benchmarks and design standards (similar to Web Content Accessibility Guidelines) for emotional access in civic and public technology, with the intention to become a kitemark.
6. Inclusion of affective safety in equity and risk assessments for digital systems
7. Support the development and adoption of attunement metrics to complement accessibility and usability benchmarks - ensuring systems are measured by how they feel as well as how they function

Closing Reflections

This paper argues for emotional access as a condition for digital systems that aim to serve everyone.

People move through systems not only with logic, but with feeling, memory, rhythm, and trust. If a system is not designed to accommodate this type of interaction, it therefore is not fully inclusive.

The alternative is to build digital systems that welcome difference not only in identity, but in mood and cognition. Emotional access should not be a feature or an afterthought, but a shared standard to ensure inclusive systems.

Disclaimer

The target audiences outlined in this paper are a result of a hypothesis of community groups that are predicted to benefit from emotional access. However, exploratory systems that are better designed to respond to inner experience have the potential to resonate with all audiences.

All direct quotes are anecdotes were gathered from a focus group composed of 45 neurodivergent and neurotypical people.

4 Appendix

Key terms

Digital Trust: Digital trust refers to “the confidence that users place in the ability of technology, people, and processes to create a secure and reliable digital environment” (SenseTime, 2025).

An example of a digital trust framework is available here: https://initiatives.weforum.org/digital-trust/framework

Non-linear design: Non-linear web design is about “breaking free from the constraints of traditional, linear layouts and navigation” (North, 2025).

Crip-time: Is “an orientation to time that centres the multifaceted relationships that Disabled people have with and in time (i.e., requiring additional time, following strict schedules)” (Furlong, 2023).

Emotional Access: Emotional accessibility refers to “creating an environment or designing products that are inclusive and considerate of individuals’ emotional needs, allowing everyone to freely express and acknowledge their emotions without judgment or barriers” (RIDM, n.d.).

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